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As *omoŋina*, a woman has many prerogatives formerly denied her. She can talk more publicly, even to the point of being raucous and openly aggressive; she is permitted to drink beer at beer parties, though not to sit with the men; she can expect a certain amount of help when she needs it from her daughters-in-law and grandchildren. A woman who gives birth at seventeen or eighteen can become *omoŋina* in her early thirties and be a grandmother as young as thirty-five, when she has another decade of childbearing herself. After menopause, in her later forties, she should have circumcised grandchildren, and her primary interests are focused on her sons' and daughters' children, who will visit and joke with her and perhaps live with her. At her husband's death, her sons' claims to land will be based on what she cultivated when he was alive, so she is in effect the trustee of that part of his estate belonging to his sons.

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This brief sketch of life stages for Gusii men and women provides no more than an overview of a complex topic, but it does bring some general points to the fore. First, transitions among the life stages of the Gusii are not based simply on chronological age, particularly after marriage. There is a status hierarchy among married adults of each sex; in this hierarchy, those with no married children are at the bottom, those with married children higher, those with grandchildren higher yet, and grandparents with no living seniors of the same sex in the same homestead are at the top. Within the homestead, seniority is based on generational age and, within a generation, on birth order. One moves up by the births and growth of those below and by the deaths of those above.

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Getting older is inherently positive if the reproductive cycle is working as it should, that is, if marriage, birth, and death are occurring at expected times and with expected results. If they do not, there is concern, anxiety, potential conflict.

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The Gusii life plan as a cultural schema takes account of certain deviations from its normative timetable, particularly ones that threaten the continuity of the minimal lineage based in the homestead. If a patriarch dies without living sons, for example, leaving a postmenopausal widow who has no one with her (since daughters move away at marriage), she can use the cattle from a daughter's marriage to "marry" a woman. The woman comes to live as a wife and has sexual relations with a local man, attempting to bear "sons" for the deceased who will inherit his land and take care of the widow  90 in her old age. Similarly, if a married couple has numerous daughters but no son until the end of the woman's childbearing years, when she is perhaps forty-five and her husband fifty-five (or more), they may reach the ages of sixty and seventy, respectively, without grandchildren living at home and may authorize their son to be married at fifteen (to a woman older than himself) so that they might "see" grandchildren before they die; this young marriage is called *okoboerwa* and is also possible when the mother of sons dies and the bride is brought in to keep house for them in the short run as well as to produce grandchildren as early as possible. Thus, there are extraordinary formal arrangements to call upon when the reproductive cycle does not produce results in accordance with Gusii ideals.

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